

To what extent do traditional counting statistics like points, assists etc. fail to capture a player's contextual value in high-leverage ('clutch') situations across professional sports?

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Abstract:

Debates and discussion are normal occurrences in sports. Carrying forward one such discussion, this paper will try to deliberate on how important are statistics in determining the importance of a player in high intensity and demanding situations. In this process, it will touch upon some facts, controversies, opinions and also, some of the most established and hot debates in sports history before ultimately arriving at a discursive ground. The study will also scan through various verified sources and without claiming support to either side of the argument, will aim at bringing an all-round and diverse understanding of the problem statement.

Keywords: Clutch, Sports, Statistics, Individual Brilliance, Football

1. Introduction

Sports, like any other professional field, has its own dilemmas, dynamics and terminology. This terminology includes simple terms like points, score, save etc. which even the non-sports fans know but also, some non-common terms like clutch, stat-padding, parking the bus etc. These uncommon terms are sometimes also called sports slang. This research will deliberate on one such term, 'clutch', and there by, engage in a specific discussion involving

statistics and players' contextual value with respect to sports. For convenience and ease of explanation, the major sport in focus would be football, although the study will involve other sports too in the discourse as and when needed. The major problem statement of this study is to understand the extent to which traditional sports statistics like points, assists etc. describe or justify a player's importance in clutch situations.

In everyday life, the term 'clutch' has several meanings including holding something tightly or close to the body (Cambridge Dictionary, n.d.) or a mechanical component in a vehicle responsible for manual transmission i.e. switching gears without stalling the vehicle (testbook, n.d.) but in sports, it is used in an entirely different context, although somewhere related to the mechanical clutch. To 'clutch' in a sports game would mean a team or player recovering from a losing position, stabilizing and breaking even and then proceeding to win the game, or basically, performing exceptionally well in high-pressure situations (Schweickle, 2021). If accomplished, clutch moments become the most thrilling part of a game. Some examples of clutch in sports can be a football team losing 3 nil by the half time and winning the game later by 4-3, a cricket team successfully chasing 300+ runs with 8 wickets down, Tennis players winning first serve points or holding the lead in high stake matches like semi-finals and so on.

The opposite of 'clutching' is usually denoted as 'choking' which refers to a severe downgrade in performance of an athlete or a team especially when it is required; the high pressure moments. It can be understood as the familiar feeling of literally choking or being unable to speak in a high pressure interview or phone call or not remembering an answer you had been mugging up all night in the examination hall. It can be accompanied by the panicking, 'freezing' of the body, sweating, illegible speech or even dilation of the pupils. Apart from physical impairments and reduced performance in the moment, choking can also give rise to fear,

self loathing and daunting and even PTSD, like it happened after Rio 2016 Olympics with the renowned Danish sprint canoeist René Holten Poulsen, who is also a three time Olympian and boasts multiple world titles. After winning a silver medal in 2008 Beijing Olympic and a double world championship gold in 2015, Poulsen was shattered when he came sixth in Rio 2016 and could not even reach the podium (top 3). He was the fan favourite it came as a shock to the fans. Poulsen later attributed the loss to lack of time for preparations and health issues but the loss came in the form of PTSD which followed him to Tokyo 2020 Olympics and many other events. He was ultimately diagnosed with PTSD and has been on his journey towards improvement ever since. (Meister and Lavanchy, 2022) (Olympics, 2020). Choking is one such term in modern sports slang that is very popular in use and is casually thrown around but it can also be a sign of something more serious. Ultimately, it represents the darker side of sports and indeed, imparts it the true essence of being a profession of the humans, for the humans and by the humans.

Likewise, another important term that will expand the research question is ‘stat-padding’. Statistics in sports refers to methods or metrics that are used to narrate a team or individual player’s position or situation in a game. Some examples can be runs or wickets in cricket, goals and assists in football, points in badminton and so on. Stat-padding refers to basically padding or protecting the statistics. In simpler words, when a player tries to improve his or her personal achievements regardless of whether it is of benefit to the team or even contributing to the win, he or she can be called a stat-padder (YourDictionary, n.d.). An example of this can be a football player goes for the goal himself or herself, deliberately not passing it to the player who is in the best position to score and probably win the game for the team or a batter in cricket playing slow and carefully while chasing the target, so as to complete his or her century (100 runs) and not making the team’s victory a necessary goal.

The next important term in this discussion is ‘scouting’. Scouting is a process done by a team, usually franchise leagues, sometimes in national teams, to identify and enlist emerging talented and suitable players from around the world and sign them to play for you before other teams and ‘scouts’ locate them (Junior Grassroots Hub, n.d.). Sometimes, scouting and signing proves to be a difference between winning the league or sometimes, dominating the entire sport for decades. The most famous example here can be of Manchester United, an English football club signing Cristiano Ronaldo, possibly the most famous and iconic football player ever. He played for Sporting Lisbon, his boyhood Portuguese club and was on an 8 season contract with them from 2002-2010, earning approximately 1 million USD a year. He was observed, scouted and signed in by Manchester United in 2004 for almost 3 million USD a year which was later increased to 4.5 million USD and subsequently, nearly 12 million USD until he was scouted again by Real Madrid at 16 million USD which was subsequently increased to approximately 23 and 27 million USD. He was then bought by Juventus in 2018 for nearly 36 million USD. Currently, he is 42 years old and receives over 200 million USD a year from his current Saudi Arabian club, Al-Nassr (Cooper, 2025) (GOAL, 2025). He also became the first ever billionaire footballer in 2025 (AlJazeera, 2025). The journey of Cristiano Ronaldo does not just exemplify the importance of scouting but also, individual brilliance and the significance of ‘clutch’ moments which will be highlighted later in the paper.

It is common knowledge that like every other field of entertainment or competition, sports is also a very vibrant industry and so, it is continuously evolving too. A study from 2019 estimated the emerging ‘sports analytics’ market to be valued at 4 billion USD by 2022. This includes different sets of physical technology like wearables to track players’ movement patterns across the pitch, Automated video analysis, 3D motion pictures to have a better understanding of

technique, expanding the business through tech-giants partnerships with teams and players and ultimately improving viewer interaction, engagement and experience through infographics and data patterns (Ricky, 2021). Likewise, the introduction of VAR (Video Assistant Referee) is a relatively new addition to football where now, important decisions like penalties and red cards are not awarded or imposed based on the referees' instincts and first impressions but slow motion replays and multiple angles. Moreover, audiences and viewers sitting at home can also watch these decisions being taken live. It was introduced in 2017/18 in *Bundesliga* (German), 2018/19 in *La Liga* (Spanish domestic league) and in 2019/20 in the English Premier League (Premier League, 2020) (Bundesliga, 2019) (LaLiga, 2018).

More recently, artificial intelligence has had an upsurge in the sports industry. AI tools for sports are no longer a 'futuristic' thought and are already being deployed to go beyond 'traditional statistics'; to predict scorelines, fatigue and motion using machine-learning algorithms, assess players' speed and efficiency in real time, detect injury and supporting recovery and helping managers and coaches make more informed decisions etc (Jain, 2025). An important reason why AI is soaring high in sports industry is because if let's say club A does not use AI and manage themselves through traditional ways, they are bound to be in a position of deficit if their opponent, say club B uses these tools and so, everyone who wants a competitive edge over their opponents will have to move forward with time.

Likewise, the game rules change as per necessity or demand too and there are functional, high profile authorities that look over the said process. The following discussion will discuss some of these in detail with reference to Football. The IFAB (International Football Association Board), which crafts rules and regulations for the top level football leagues like English Premier league, La Liga, Bundesliga, UEFA Champions league (European competition) and even FIFA

(*Fédération Internationale de Football Association* or the International Association Football Federation), issued certain new guidelines to be followed from the 2025/26 season onwards. These include the ‘only captain rule’ according to which, in case of a dispute on the field, only the captains of the teams will be allowed to talk and express their side’s concern. This is introduced to prevent the players from ganging up on the referee to influence decisions. Next is the ‘eight second rule’ for goal keepers where they can not control the ball inside the penalty box for more than eight seconds and have to pass it to their players. Failing to do so will reward a corner kick to the other team. This is introduced to prevent the advantageous side from wasting the time and deliberately stopping opportunities for the other team. There are many such minor rulebook changes applied but by and large, the aim behind these changes is to learn from the past controversies so as to avoid them in future (Premier League, 2025).

To also exemplify this in the case of cricket, a major controversy erupted after the 2019 cricket World Cup final when the finalists, England and New Zealand, drew their score totals. As per the rules, there was a super-over meaning both the teams get 6 deliveries each and the team with most runs scored in the super-over wins. The game however, went on to witness an extremely rare situation where both the teams drew their scores even in the super-over and as per the then rulebook guidelines, England was declared the winner because of more boundary count throughout the match. This was a shock to the cricket world as many felt that New Zealand had been cheated on. Following the massive controversy, the ICC (International Cricket Council) modified the rule and scrapped the boundary count rule. As of now, the rule is for the super-over to continue as long as there is no clear winner in finals and semi-finals (ESPNcricinfo Staff, 2019).

The newly introduced rules are always based on experience and it is owing to this dynamic nature of sports that this study would also assume a difference between traditional and relatively newer metrics of statistics; traditional statistics being goals, points, runs etc and the emerging or relatively new metrics like xG (expected goals), being categorized as non-traditional statistics. The next section of this study will dive deep into the subject matter to try and answer the problem statement and in the due process, will utilize the terms discussed above and through individual and team case studies from different sports. Although the key arguments will be discussing sports in general, the locus of this research will centre primarily around football, following an inductive approach of going from particular to general.

2. The Problem and the Discussion: The Role of Statistics in Deciding the Clutch Factor and the ‘Value’ of a player

The target problem of this study is researching to what extent, do statistics or traditional statistics decide a player’s value in high intensity and ‘clutch’ situations. This will take the study through understanding the role of statistics and revisiting their validity. It will also bring the discussion back to the age-old question; should the difference in statistics primarily decide if a player is better than the others? The answer is both yes and no and it primarily lies in a person’s subjective definition of claiming what ‘better’ is.

It is hard and practically, stupid as well to argue against the statement “statistics speak for themselves”. This is because viewpoints may differ, loyalties may shift, metrics may evolve and skills may deteriorate over time but the numbers never lie or change. If, for instance, someone says that Cristiano Ronaldo is the greatest footballer ever because he is the only player ever to score 100+ goals for 4 different clubs; Manchester United, Real Madrid, Juventus and Al-Nassr

and his country, Portugal (Verma, 2025) which shows his undeniable skill set, no matter which country or league he plays in. He also became the first player to be a top scorer in three different leagues, that is *Serie A*, Premier League and *La Liga* (Richardson, 2021). He is also the only player thus far to have scored in five different World Cups tournaments; 2006, 2010, 2014, 2018, 2022 (Garcia, 2022) and is also lined up to play in the upcoming 2026 World Cup. These are just a few out of dozens of brilliant statistics Ronaldo has achieved and they point towards his unreal longevity, and dedication to the game, something which is perfectly depicted by statistics.

A discourse on football, great players and statistics will undoubtedly take the discussion to probably the greatest sports rivalries, the Messi vs Ronaldo debate. Both of them are active currently and are without question, two most successful and skilled footballers of all time. While Ronaldo has scored most goals i.e. 965 as of March 2026 and is chasing 1000 goals, an unprecedented feat (Becherano, 2026), Messi tops the list of most assists^[1] in football history, with over 400 assists. Messi has won a world cup with Argentina, Ronaldo is yet to achieve the feat with Portugal. Ronaldo has won more UEFA Champions Leagues than Messi and has more knock out (clutch) goals but Messi has won 8 Ballon D'ors, compared to 5 by Ronaldo (messivsronaldo, 2026). There are many more such comparisons possible and probably, the football world would never be able to settle the debate but the bottom line is that the Messi vs Ronaldo debate is essential to this topic.

Speaking of the recorded statistics available, even when one of the two has a better record, neither has a bad record either. Many fans of Messi and Ronaldo also believe that more than statistics, it is what the player does on the field that gets stuck in people's minds and that it is not always possible to measure greatness by statistics, a statement which does seem to have

some truth in it. Moreover, many fans on both sides of the debate complain of the ambiguities of statistics and awards. The following paragraph will discuss the same.

The ambiguity of Awards is also a factor. Sometimes, statistics can become the reason why certain players focus on the personal achievement of targets instead of desired game interest (as discussed through ‘stat-padding’ in chapter 1). What this also means is that sometimes, the statistics can be manipulated out of context or new measures can be created which later become an intrinsic part of the game analysis and the sport itself. An example of this is ‘assists’. An assist in football is similar to the word’s general usage in the English language which is to help or support. An assist in football refers to the last ball pass delivered to the goalscorer by one of the team mates (Jobsinfootball, 2026). The person scoring the goal becomes the goalscorer and is awarded the due credit while the passer gets to have an assist. There is, however, a catch here. An assist is given on the basis of the second-last last touch on the ball before the goal. It sometimes can be well earned by the assist-giver, it might also be earned through another team mates effort and just passed to the 2nd last player. An assist is significant in a team’s win but unlike a goal which is 100% credited to the goal-scorer, it has often been contested as a measure to use for deciding individual brilliance awards.

Moreover, counting assists as ‘Goals/Assist’ or G/A was not a statistics in football until the 1986 Football World Cup made an unofficial effort to count it for the first time and the 1994 Football World Cup included it in statistics officially. A technical study group of the 1986 Football World Cup reported that they had made such an attempt for the first time. They were, in their words, aware of the fact that there “was no objective criteria to allot assists.” The scoring list was established according to the following rules; an assist was awarded to the player who had given the last pass to the goalscorer. In addition, the third-last holder of the ball could get an

assist provided that his action had decisive importance for the goal. Then, after goals from rebounds those players were awarded an assist who had shot on target. After goals scored on penalty or by a directly converted free-kick, the fouled player received a point. In case that the goalscorer had laid on the goal for himself (dribble, solo run), no assists were awarded and finally, no assists were awarded the goalscorer took advantage of a missed pass by an opponent (World Cup Technical Report, 1986, p.198).

Likewise, awards are not untouched by such controversies. Similar to this, another contested measure of ‘greatness’ is the Ballon D’or. It is the confluence of statistics, popularity and practical team impact. It is an annual individual award by the magazine ‘France Football’. Started in 1956, it went on to become arguably, the most prestigious individual award in football. Initially limited to European players at European clubs, the award’s eligibility expanded to all players playing in Europe in 1995 and then to all players worldwide in 2007. Ballon D’or for women was introduced in 2018 and Ada Hegerberg of Norway, while playing for OL Lyonnes became the first recipient (Britannica Editors, 2025).

Selection of a Ballon D’or winner is a long and tedious process, given the stature and prestige of the reward. 30 best players during the stipulated time (11 months from August of one year to July of next year) are shortlisted. Following this, a panel composed of one journalist from each of the top 100 footballing nations ranked by FIFA (one from top 50 for women’s Ballon D’or) vote to determine the winner. Every voter prepares a list of his or her top 10 players, which are then given 15, 12, 10, 8, 7, 5, 4, 3, 2, and 1 point, respectively, depending on their ranking. Then, total points in each list are tallied and so, the player with the most points wins the award. In case of a tie, most 1st position ratings are counted. If tied again, most 2nd, then 3rd and so on until the tie is broken (Britannica Editors, 2025).

The controversies around Ballon D'or, however, are primarily on the basis of the selection process and criteria. It is often said that the award is generally biased towards attacking midfielders and forwards and ignores defensive play. This is backed by the fact that only two centre-backs (Beckenbauer and Fabio Cannavaro) and one goalkeeper (Lev Yashin) have ever won the award. The jury also seems to vote for belonging to teams that have won the major trophies, an act which sometimes defeats the purpose of an individual award. For some fans and critics, the Ballon D'or, an award for individual brilliance, is an award which goes against the game of football, a team sport. Additionally, since the voters or selectors are journalists and not actual players, coaches or footballers, a large section of the football world questions the authenticity of the award (Austin, 2025). In 2010, for instance, Wesley Sneijder of Netherlands (runner ups of the FIFA World Cup 2010), had also won the treble, *Serie A* (Italian domestic league), Coppa Italia and the Champions League with Inter Milan but Lionel Messi ended up winning the award, which raised the eyebrows of many fans. Likewise, when Pavel Nedved won the award in 2003, he won over Thierry Henry of France who had 42 goals and 26 assists in 68 matches across all competitions (Foot Africa, 2025). There are multiple such instances in the awards history but overall, since it is an award based on votes, which are subjective and not necessarily based on hard statistics, it is always contestable, somewhere similar to the subject matter of this research paper; should statistics decide the importance of a player in clutch situations?

When it comes to statistics related to 'clutching' in football, a study conducted over 10 years (2010 - 2020) on Europe's biggest 5 leagues in football namely English Premier League, Spanish La Liga, Italian Serie A, German Bundesliga, French Ligue 1 and UEFA Champions League had some noteworthy findings. 127 players in this duration had produced 100 goals and

assists. Out of these, just 12 had produced at least 15 goals and assists in ‘clutch’ moments i.e. last and final minutes of the games; post 80th minute or when the teams were tied on goals or one was on deficit and needed a goal. The top 2 players in the said list were Messi (16 goals, 9 assists, total 25 clutch contributions) and Ronaldo (22 goals and 2 assists, total 24 clutch combinations). This takes the discussion back to assists and their relevance to the study because some here would argue that Ronaldo is a better clutch player, for he has scored 6 more goals in the high-demand and intense moments while for some, Messi’s 7 more assists vouch for his overall performance and dominance in the team. Another famous player in the list, Mario Balotelli, has a contribution of 17 goals and 1 assist but out of that, has 9 penalties scored out of 9 attempts, which is a striking 100% clutch penalty rate. Likewise, Romelu Lukaku, 3rd in the list after Messi and Ronaldo with 17 goals and 4 assists has the highest scoring probability in the late and close moments; 9.3% (Connelly, 2021). There are many more players in the sample who might not have had such consistent and massive impacts but one or two major moments which counted a lot for their sides. Ultimately, it shows how intricate and layered the scoring analysis of clutch moments is and further complicates the discussion. Switching to the NBA, in the 2023 NBA season Jimmy Butler averaged 22.9 points per game, 5.9 rebounds per game and 5.3 assists per game. Whereas in the playoffs, he averaged 26.9 points per game, 6.5 rebounds and 5.9 assists, taking the 8th seeded Miami Heat to the NBA finals and performing when it mattered the most. (statmuse.com)

The central problem in this study, which is basically that how relevant are statistics of a player in deciding their ‘clutch’ value is not a simple, black and white question to answer. Without question, statistics are generally considered as markers of quality and dependability of a player. Whenever there is a discussion about the batting in cricket, Sachin Tendulkar or Virat

Kohli have to enter the conversation. Sachin has retired from all formats of the game and still tops the most runs scored list with 34,357 runs, exceeding Virat Kohli, who is still partially active and is the second highest runs scorer, considered by some to be the best batter ever, by a margin of over 6000 runs (ESPN Cric info, n.d.). The stats and even Kohli's own words suggest that Sachin is a far superior batter, someone who is complete in all-round his game and has inspired generations of batters, including Virat Kohli himself (News18, 2022).

That being said, when it comes to high pressure clutch situations (usually, during run chases), the cricket world unanimously agrees on the massive impact of Virat Kohli, also called 'The Chasemaster'. As of March 2025, Kohli had scored over 8000 runs with an average of 65 runs per innings and 41 fifties during ODI (One-Day International, the 50 over per-side game) run chases. He had also scored 54% of his centuries during chases, that made up to 28 centuries, more than any player in the second innings of ODI cricket by far (Jain, 2025). In this case, Kohli is certainly a great clutch player but also has fantastic statistics including most centuries and runs, second only to Sachin Tendulkar, who for the record, has had a career of 24 years, compared to Kohli's ongoing 16 years career (ESPN Cric info, n.d.). Another example debating the relevance of statistics on 'clutch' value is the 2019 Wimbledon final between Novak Djokovic and Roger Federer. Federer had a whopping 26 aces to Djokovic's 10; Federer's first serve percentage was 64% to Djokovic's 59%; Federer had a 78% win % on first serves to Djokovic's 74%. Federer won a total of 36 games and 218 points, to Novak's 32 games and 204 points. Despite all the significant stats of tennis pointing towards Federer it was Djokovic who won the match.

Debates like this are fascinating and can be found in every sport but for the subject matter of this paper, yet again proves that statistics and clutch situation antiques go hand in hand. If

clutching in a game is not accompanied by consistency, it might get called fluke. In the words of Peter Keating, a renowned sports analyst, "Athletes aren't clutch because they raise their level of play in important situations; that's not a real, sustainable skill. Instead, these athletes are clutch because they don't choke as much relative to their peers" (Connelly, 2021).

3. Conclusion and Resolution:

At the end of the day, choosing 'better' performers or players with more important contributions to their teams or the game at large is a subjective decision. While some sports enthusiasts believe that statistics speak for themselves and they can be excellent only when the player who has them was excellent, there are many for whom statistics are certainly a measure of excellence but being 'the greatest' goes far beyond numbers and figures. For them, being a great player has a lot to do with showing up when the team needs you, fighting hard in do-or-die situations or sometimes, just giving your one hundred percent.

This concludes the discussion; it will be factually incorrect to deem statistics irrelevant to the discussion of a player's significance in clutch situations but that being said, statistics should also not be the primary parameter to decide the clutch-significance of players because ultimately, in a World Cup final, it would not matter even if the goal keeper shows up to score the winning goal.

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